GUARD YOUR WEB APPLICATIONS AGAINST THE TOP 10 VULNERABILITIES

A flawed Web application is a security risk. OWASP's 'Top 10 Vulnerabilities' is a powerful document that raises awareness about the dangers out there and pinpoints possible flaws in a Web application. It also suggests ways and means to counter these susceptibilities. OWASP enjoys the support and backing of security experts from around the world.

Allow me to begin this article by asking a simple question. Can you say, with absolute surety, that your house is theft-proof? If your answer is, "Yes," then you're living under a false sense of security. However, if your answer is "No," then we have something to talk about. You may have state-of-the-art security systems installed in your home but none will be a good enough match against determined burglars. The security system will definitely make their task difficult, but it won't be able to stop them. All that would be required is for them to find the Achilles heel of your security system. You might wonder that if no security system is good then why even bother installing one? Why not leave your house wide open for the burglar? While security systems might not block out the burglars entirely, they will enable you to protect the vulnerable spots of your house and give you enough time to detect the burglars and take action.

If you replace the word 'house' with 'Web application' in the above scenario, the argument is still valid. The only difference is that the number of vulnerable spots in a Web application is much more than in a house. Also, given the fact that a Web application will most likely be exposed to the world at large, the number of threat agents and attack vectors increases exponentially. Therefore, in order to develop a secure Web application, developers will have to think of each of the possible ways in which their app can be compromised. Considering that there are more than 500,000 ways in which this can be done, by the time the application is ready to hit the market after being tested, it might already be out-of-date. How do developers then ensure that they develop a secure application without any significant impact on its time to market and its usability? The answer to this lies in the Open Web Application Security Project (OWASP).